APOTI DEVELOPMENT ASSOCIATION

First Widow Home Visits Project Report

ADA/2021/001 · November 1–30, 2021 · Buea, South-West Region, Cameroon

Retrospective review copy (November 2026): Financial wording was revised from owner recollection. This review does not independently verify other narrative details, participant counts, or the project balance.

REPORT source markdown

3 elderly widows (as reported in the source; not independently verified)

Prepared for public download

REFERENCE	LOCATION
ADA/2021/001	**Buea, South-West Region, Cameroon**
PERIOD	BUDGET / SPEND
November 1–30, 2021	**—**

Project Completion Report

FIELD	DETAILS
Project Title	First Widow Home Visits
Organization	Apoti Development Association (ADA)
Reference Number	ADA/2021/001
Project Location	Buea, South-West Region, Cameroon
Implementation Period	November 1–30, 2021
Total Beneficiaries	3 elderly widows (as reported in the source; not independently verified)
Financial status	Owner-recalled figures are not independently reconciled
Report Date	December 15, 2021

Retrospective review copy (November 2026): Financial wording was revised from owner recollection. This review does not independently verify other narrative details, participant counts, or the project balance.

1. Executive Summary

In November 2021, the Apoti Development Association (ADA) carried out its inaugural community outreach project — a series of door-to-door home visits to elderly widows in Buea, South-West Region, Cameroon. A team of three female university-age volunteers identified and visited three elderly widows living in conditions of extreme vulnerability, delivering bags of rice, offering prayer and emotional support, assessing living conditions, and documenting urgent needs. This modest but deeply meaningful project marked the official launch of ADA as a faith-based organization committed to serving vulnerable communities, and the findings from these visits laid the groundwork for all subsequent programming.

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2. Project Background

2.1 Context

The South-West Region of Cameroon has experienced significant social disruption since 2016 due to the ongoing Anglophone crisis. Displacement, economic hardship, and the breakdown of traditional community support structures have left many elderly widows without adequate care. In Buea, widows who have lost their husbands often face isolation, food insecurity, and deteriorating living conditions — particularly those too elderly or infirm to work.

2.2 Organizational Context

ADA was founded in 2021 by a group of young, faith-driven individuals in Cameroon who felt called to serve the most vulnerable members of their community. At the time of this project, the organization had no formal registration, no office, and no prior experience implementing community projects. The First Widow Home Visits project was conceived as both a direct act of service and a learning exercise — a way to understand the needs of the community firsthand before designing larger interventions.

2.3 Rationale

The project was motivated by:

- Reports from church communities about elderly widows living alone in difficult conditions
- A desire to move from intention to action — to officially begin ADA's mission
- The need to gather firsthand data on the living conditions of vulnerable widows in Buea

- A faith-based conviction that even small acts of compassion can have transformative impact

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3. Objectives vs Achievements

#	PLANNED OBJECTIVE	ACHIEVEMENT	STATUS
1	Visit at least 3 elderly widows in their homes	3 widows visited in their homes	✅ Achieved
2	Deliver food assistance (rice, oil, condiments) to each widow	Food packages delivered to all 3 widows	✅ Achieved
3	Assess and document living conditions	Conditions documented for all 3 households	✅ Achieved
4	Provide spiritual and emotional support	Prayer sessions held with each widow	✅ Achieved
5	Identify urgent needs for future intervention	Critical needs identified (shelter, healthcare, childcare)	✅ Achieved
6	Officially launch ADA's community work	Organization launched through this first act of service	✅ Achieved

Overall Achievement Rate: 100%

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4. Activities Implemented

4.1 Preparation Phase (November 1–7)

The volunteer team spent the first week identifying potential beneficiaries through word-of-mouth referrals from local church communities and neighbors. This process proved more challenging than anticipated — many widows live in isolated locations without clear addresses, and community members were sometimes hesitant to share personal information about their neighbors.

The team organized procurement of food items and transportation for reaching the widows' homes. The source of project funds is not independently verified in this review.

4.2 Visit One: The Widow Living Alone

The first visit was to an elderly widow estimated to be in her late 70s, living alone in a small rented room in a compound house. The volunteers arrived with a bag of rice, introduced themselves and the purpose of their visit, and spent time listening to her story. She had lost her husband over a decade ago and had no children nearby to support her. The team prayed with her, documented her living conditions (basic but clean, limited food stores, no visible health concerns), and noted her primary need: companionship and regular food support.

4.3 Visit Two: The Widow with a Small Garden

The second widow, estimated to be in her early 70s, was found in a modest home with a small garden she tended for subsistence. Though in better physical condition than the first, she expressed deep loneliness and financial anxiety. She was unable to afford medical care for recurring joint pain. The volunteers delivered rice, prayed with her, and documented her need for basic healthcare access and economic support.

4.4 Visit Three: The Bedridden Widow in the Makeshift Shelter

The third visit was the most impactful and emotionally difficult for the team. The volunteers found an elderly widow — estimated to be in her 80s — bedridden in a makeshift shelter with walls partially covered by paper and cardboard to block wind and rain.

Despite her condition, she was the primary caregiver for a young grandchild whose parents were absent. The shelter offered minimal protection from the elements, and the widow's health was visibly deteriorating.

The volunteers delivered rice, prayed with the widow and her grandchild, and spent extended time documenting the conditions. This visit profoundly affected the team and became a defining moment for ADA's mission — a concrete illustration of why the organization needed to exist.

4.5 Post-Visit Documentation (November 20–30)

Following the visits, the team compiled notes, discussed findings, and began planning next steps. Photographs were taken (with consent) to document conditions for future reference and fundraising purposes.

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5. Beneficiary Profiles

All names have been withheld to protect the privacy and dignity of the beneficiaries.

Beneficiary A — "The Quiet One"

- **Estimated age:** Late 70s
- **Living situation:** Single rented room in a compound house
- **Health status:** Mobile, no acute health concerns observed
- **Family support:** No children or relatives nearby
- **Primary needs:** Regular food supply, companionship, social connection
- **Notable observations:** Clean and organized living space despite limited resources; expressed gratitude for the visit and said no one had checked on her in months

Beneficiary B — "The Gardener"

- **Estimated age:** Early 70s
- **Living situation:** Modest home with small subsistence garden
- **Health status:** Mobile but experiencing chronic joint pain
- **Family support:** Limited; some distant relatives but no regular contact
- **Primary needs:** Healthcare access, economic support, food supplementation
- **Notable observations:** Resourceful and independent but increasingly unable to maintain her garden; worried about what would happen when she could no longer tend it

Beneficiary C — "The Grandmother"

- **Estimated age:** Early 80s
- **Living situation:** Makeshift shelter with paper-covered walls; bedridden
- **Health status:** Bedridden, visibly deteriorating health, no access to medical care
- **Family support:** Caring for one grandchild; parents of the child absent
- **Primary needs:** Urgent shelter repair or relocation, medical attention, childcare support, consistent food supply
- **Notable observations:** Despite her condition, her primary concern was for her grandchild's welfare rather than her own; the shelter was structurally unsafe and offered inadequate protection from weather

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6. Outcomes & Impact

6.1 Immediate Outcomes

- **Food security (short-term):** Each widow received a food package (25kg rice, cooking oil, and condiments) sufficient for approximately 2–3 weeks of meals
- **Spiritual and emotional support:** All three widows expressed deep appreciation for the prayer and companionship; two stated it was the first visit they had received in months

- **Dignity and recognition:** The act of visiting communicated to each widow that she was seen, valued, and not forgotten by her community

6.2 Organizational Outcomes

- **ADA officially launched:** This project transformed ADA from an idea into an active organization
- **Needs assessment completed:** The team now had firsthand knowledge of the conditions facing elderly widows in Buea
- **Team formation:** The three volunteers solidified their commitment to ADA's mission through shared experience
- **Documentation created:** Photos and notes from the visits became the foundation for future fundraising and program design

6.3 Longer-Term Impact

- The findings from Visit Three (the bedridden widow in the makeshift shelter) became a catalyst for ADA's subsequent shelter and housing initiatives
- The emotional impact on volunteers strengthened their resolve and attracted additional volunteers in subsequent months
- The project established ADA's model of combining material assistance with spiritual care and needs documentation

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7. Challenges & Lessons Learned

7.1 Challenges Encountered

CHALLENGE	DESCRIPTION	HOW IT WAS ADDRESSED
Locating beneficiaries	No formal addresses; relied on verbal directions and community referrals	Spent additional time asking neighbors; arrived early to allow for searching
Emotional impact on volunteers	The conditions witnessed — particularly the bedridden widow — were emotionally overwhelming for the young team	Team debriefed together after each visit; leaned on faith and prayer for processing
Limited resources	Limited available resources meant only basic food items could be provided; could not address shelter or medical needs	Documented needs for future projects; accepted the limitation of this first effort
No organizational infrastructure	No transport, no office, no formal processes	Used personal phones for documentation; walked or used public transport; coordinated via WhatsApp
Community trust	Some community members were initially suspicious of young strangers asking about vulnerable widows	Introduced themselves through church connections; explained ADA's mission clearly

7.2 Lessons Learned

1. **Start where you are.** ADA did not wait for perfect conditions, formal registration, or large funding to begin serving. The act of starting — however small — was itself transformative for both the beneficiaries and the organization.

2. **Emotional preparation matters.** Young volunteers encountering extreme poverty and suffering for the first time need support structures. Future projects should include pre-visit briefings and post-visit debriefing sessions.

3. **Documentation is essential.** The notes and photos from these visits proved invaluable for future planning, fundraising, and organizational storytelling. Every project should prioritize documentation from day one.

4. **Food is necessary but not sufficient.** While the rice was appreciated, the widows' most pressing needs were often structural (shelter, healthcare, companionship). Future programming must address root causes, not just symptoms.

5. **Community entry requires relationships.** Finding and accessing vulnerable individuals requires trust and local connections. ADA should invest in building relationships with community leaders, churches, and local authorities.

6. **Small teams can accomplish meaningful work.** Three volunteers began ADA's community work through this project and documented needs for future planning.

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8. Photos & Documentation

Photographs were taken during the home visits with the verbal consent of each beneficiary. These images document:

- Living conditions of each widow's home
- The state of the makeshift shelter (Beneficiary C)
- Food packages delivered
- Volunteer team during visits

📁 **Photo archive location:** Project files are maintained in ADA's internal archive under reference ADA/2021/001. Photos are available upon request for reporting and fundraising purposes, subject to beneficiary privacy considerations.

Note: Due to the sensitive nature of the living conditions documented, photos are shared only in appropriate contexts and with respect for the dignity of the individuals pictured.

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9. Recommendations for Future Projects

Based on the findings and lessons from this inaugural project, the team recommends the following:

9.1 Immediate Follow-Up

1. **Return visits:** Schedule monthly follow-up visits to all three widows to maintain relationship and monitor conditions
2. **Urgent intervention for Beneficiary C:** Her shelter situation requires immediate attention — explore options for repair, relocation, or community-supported rebuilding
3. **Medical referral:** Connect Beneficiary C with local health services or a community health worker

9.2 Program Development

4. **Expand beneficiary identification:** Develop a systematic process for identifying vulnerable widows through churches, community leaders, and local social services
5. **Diversify assistance:** Move beyond food-only support to include healthcare access, shelter improvement, and companionship programs
6. **Volunteer training:** Develop a brief orientation program for new volunteers covering emotional preparedness, documentation standards, and community engagement protocols

9.3 Organizational Growth

7. **Formal registration:** Pursue legal registration of ADA to enable formal partnerships and funding applications
8. **Fundraising strategy:** Use documentation from this project to develop fundraising materials for larger interventions
9. **Partnership development:** Connect with local churches, health facilities, and other NGOs for referral pathways and resource sharing
10. **Record-keeping systems:** Establish simple but consistent systems for tracking beneficiaries, visits, and outcomes over time

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10. Financial Summary — Under Review

The owner recalls that 120,000 CFA francs was sent for the November 2021 project and estimates that about 110,000 CFA francs was spent in total, including approximately 10,000 CFA francs in withdrawal costs. The owner-recalled sent amount is approximately US$209 using the November 2021 monthly average exchange rate.

The approximately 10,000 CFA difference is arithmetic only; it is not a verified remaining balance. No independently reconciled budget, exact expenditure, itemized allocation, or returned balance is established by this report. The former itemized USD table and claims about exact variances and supporting receipts have therefore been removed pending reconciliation.

11. Conclusion

The First Widow Home Visits project was, by conventional metrics, a small intervention — three visits and food support. But its significance to the Apoti Development Association cannot be overstated. This project was the moment ADA moved from aspiration to action, from conversation to compassion in practice.

What the team found in those homes — particularly the image of an elderly, bedridden grandmother caring for a grandchild in a paper-walled shelter — became the moral foundation upon which ADA would build all of its subsequent work. It answered the question of whether the need was real, whether young people could make a difference, and whether faith could be translated into tangible service.

The three volunteers who walked those unpaved roads in November 2021 did not have experience, infrastructure, or significant resources. What they had was willingness — and that proved to be enough to begin. ADA's story starts here: not with a grand launch or a large grant, but with a bag of rice, a prayer, and the courage to knock on a stranger's door.

This report is submitted with gratitude to God and to the three widows who welcomed us into their homes and their lives.

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12. Prepared By

ADA Project Team
Apoti Development Association
Buea, South-West Region, Cameroon

Report prepared: December 2021
Reference: ADA/2021/001

"Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this: to visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction." — James 1:27

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